

1970–1979

LONG PRINTED DRESSES

In the 1970s short skirts were replaced by long, loose A-line dresses. Reminiscent of dress lengths in Victorian times, these “floor-skimmers” wowed with flower power patterns, paisley prints, feminine fabrics, and softer shades. The new decade saw young women embracing peace, love, and freedom in a clear rejection of the warring nations and corrupt capitalist societies dominating the news around the world. The shift towards idealistic notions of harmonious living was best reflected in carefree, natural attire. The ethnic styles of non-Western cultures, especially Indian clothing and fabrics, visibly influenced the dresses of the hippie movement. Styles also reflected a romantic, nostalgic view of the past, recalling the countryside or Victorian aesthetics. Many women opted for tie-dyed creations or floral patterns, personalizing their dresses and jewellery with decorative beads and tassels, and adding printed headscarves and turbans. In the 21st century maxi dresses made another appearance, as long lengths became fashionable again.

WEDGES AND PLATFORMS

While many hippies preferred to pair their long dresses with bare feet for an entirely natural look, designers were stepping up a gear with ever more exciting shoe styles. From bulky boots to strappy sandals, young women and men were spoiled for choice with the variety of shoes both available and on-trend in the 1970s. For practical purposes, heels stayed low, but when dressing to impress, wedges or platforms were the chunky choice, adding inches to leglines. Despite medical advice that these high heels were dangerous, young women put their best foot forward, creating more statuesque silhouettes than ever before.



Low-heeled lace-up boots



Wedge-heeled clogs



Platform open-toed sandals

Rich red and green colours



Extended V-neckline

Sheer, loose-fitting sleeves

Feminine fabric

Cream, tan, and mint floral print



Matching turban

Fitted shirt

Panelled skirt

Contrasting black background

Clark's creations Flamboyant British designer Ossie Clark was renowned for his flowing dresses in beautifully soft fabrics. Looking to Hollywood's glamour girls for inspiration, his lavish designs flattered the female form.

Fabric of choice Silk was another popular fabric during the 1970s. This striking ensemble consisting of a shirt, skirt, and turban in matching silk was crafted by Italian designer Pancaldi & B. in 1976.



Turban

Floral leather motifs

Leather streamers with plastic tubing

Silk lining

Full-length skirt

Skirt of many panels

Pop star production Made by British designer Bill Gibb in 1972 – who was synonymous with the maxi-length print trend – this dramatic maxi was worn by pop princess Sandie Shaw. It is made of printed cotton, and trimmed with leather and plastic.